

MY WONDER YEARS

I hated going to a private Jewish high school. I felt stifled by the forced religious aspect of my secular education. Our first “class” every morning was a prayer session, which I thought was a waste of time since God wasn’t real. (Edgy.)

We also had to carve out a significant portion of our day for Torah and Talmud studies. I wasn’t sure what purpose these classes served in the real world. (For this and more groundbreaking teen cynicism, don’t touch that dial!)

Many of the students there were well off, which I viewed at the time as some kind of moral failing. I didn’t *want* to be rich. Poverty was a virtue. I was a devotee of *RENT*, a musical about a group of delinquent artists who refuse to pay rent to their former friend and landlord, who (while doing his job) is painted as a total villain. I saw myself as one of the pure-of-heart rebels and everyone who dealt in money as sellouts.

I attended that high school on a half-tuition academic scholarship that I’d secured in eighth grade by writing an essay and passing a couple of in-person interviews. I’d attended for elementary and middle school, but high school tuition was higher. (My mom says on average it cost \$7,000 to \$8,000 a year for me to attend the lower grades, and then tuition doubled to \$15,000 a year in high school, without the scholarship.) Many students suddenly couldn’t afford to attend anymore and switched to public schools.

The students that stayed at my high school had all the usual wealth signifiers of the early aughts: aviator sunglasses, Dooney & Bourke purses, Tiffany bracelets. It was fashionable to straighten your hair until it was stick-straight, and the girls had expensive hair straighteners that made this possible. Sometimes my mom ironed my hair for me with an iron while I lay on an ironing board.

The secret breakdown of class was obvious to anyone reading the markers on the students. There was also a clear hierarchy demarcating who was able to afford tutors and who couldn’t; who could afford to stay after school and